TEACHING SCRIPT | LESSON 15

Romans Part 1

A 50 Minute Teaching Script

BIG IDEA All people stand guilty under sin, but God reveals his righteousness by justifying sinners through faith in Jesus Christ, leaving no room for boasting.

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: If God judges fairly, how can guilty people ever be right with him? Under it write: How can God be righteous and justify the guilty?

0:00-5:00 Opening question and prayer

Good morning. Today we begin Romans, one of Paul's fullest explanations of the gospel. We will not attempt to explain every verse in chapters 1-4. We will follow one argument: every person is accountable to God, and God provides in Christ the righteous verdict no one can earn.

Ask: If God judges fairly, how can guilty people ever be right with him? Take two or three responses. Then say: Our controlling question is: How can God be righteous and justify the guilty?

Let's pray. Righteous and merciful God, silence our excuses and turn our attention to what you have done in Jesus Christ. Teach us to trust your promise and to boast only in your grace. Amen.

5:00-10:00 Romans in one paragraph

Paul had not founded the Roman churches. He writes to introduce his gospel, strengthen unity among Jewish and Gentile believers, and prepare for a mission toward Spain. Romans is theology in service of mission and church unity.

Read Romans 1:16-17. This is the thesis. The gospel is God's power to save everyone who believes. It reveals God's righteousness: his righteous character expressed in judgment and in faithful saving action. The righteous God acts to put sinners in the right through faith.

10:00-20:00 Every mouth silenced

Summarize 1:18-3:8. Paul begins with humanity exchanging God's glory for idols and being handed over to the disorder it chooses. Then he turns to the person judging others. Possessing moral knowledge or the Mosaic law does not excuse disobedience. Jewish privilege is real, but privilege does not erase accountability.

Read Romans 3:9-20. Emphasize the destination: Jew and Gentile alike are under sin; every mouth is silenced; the whole world is accountable to God. The law is a true standard, but it cannot serve as a successful defense because it exposes sin.

Say: Romans 1 is not permission for one group to condemn another. Romans 2 turns the charge toward the accuser, and Romans 3 places every person together before God. No one enters chapter 3 with grounds for superiority.

20:00-35:00 God justifies through Christ

Read Romans 3:21-26. The words 'But now' announce the turn. God has acted apart from law-keeping, while the Law and the Prophets bear witness to his action. There is no difference: everyone shares the same problem, and the same gift is offered to all who believe.

Explain four words briefly:

- Justified: God's courtroom verdict that the guilty believer is in the right before him. It is a gift, not a wage.
- Grace: God acts freely for people who cannot establish a claim upon him.
- Redemption: Christ liberates sinners at the cost of his own life.
- Sacrifice of atonement: Christ's death deals with sin and shows that God does not ignore evil when he forgives.

Now answer the controlling question. Romans 3:26 says God is just and the one who justifies those who have faith in Jesus. Forgiveness is not pretending sin does not matter. At the cross, God deals with sin and gives believers the verdict they could never earn.

Read Romans 3:27-31 or summarize it. Boasting is excluded. Faith is not a superior achievement. It is the empty hand that receives God's gift. One God justifies both Jew and Gentile by faith.

35:00-43:00 Abraham believed the promise

Read Romans 4:1-5. Abraham was not paid righteousness as wages for work. He trusted God, and righteousness was credited to him. Verse 5 is deliberately startling: God justifies the ungodly. Abraham contributes no ground for boasting.

Summarize verses 6-15. Abraham was declared righteous before circumcision and long before the Mosaic law. That timeline makes him the father of uncircumcised believers as well as circumcised believers. The promise creates one family of faith.

Read Romans 4:16-25. Abraham trusted the God who gives life to the dead and keeps his promise. Paul connects that faith to Christians who trust the God who raised Jesus from the dead. Jesus was delivered over for our sins and raised for our justification.

Say: Abraham challenges pride because no one earns the promise. He also challenges despair because the promise depends on God's power and faithfulness, not ours.

43:00-48:00 Discussion choose two

1. Why does Paul show that every group is under sin?
2. How can God forgive guilty people without becoming unjust?
3. Why is faith not simply another work that earns God's approval?
4. How does Abraham's story challenge both pride and hopelessness?

If discussion runs long, stop after two questions. Do not attempt to settle every debate about Romans 1, the New Perspective, or theories of atonement. Keep the class with Paul's argument.

48:00-50:00 Synthesis homework and prayer

Here is the lesson in one sentence: No one has a case to present before God, but everyone may receive the gift God provides in Christ.

Before next week, read Romans 5-8. Mark every reference to Adam, Christ, sin, death, life, the Spirit, suffering, and hope.

Let's pray. God of grace, thank you for dealing justly with our sin and giving freely what we could never earn. Free us from boasting, strengthen our faith in your promise, and make us one people in Christ. Amen.